Returning to our previous analysis, the Panglong narrative constitutes a 'process of identification' for the Kachin, used since the KIO/A took up arms to articulate claims and mobilize nationalism. Its political effectiveness has strengthened a sense of shared 'ethnic identity', while at the same time laying claim to control central tenets of that Kachin ethnicity. It could be argued that this Kachin nationalism was a response to the growth of Burman nationalism in the push for independence, as well as the way the Burmese-dominated state employed identity difference as a means to distribute public goods and allocate privileges after independence (Walton 2013). This historical narrative, however, reinforces and solidifies Kachin identity politics as the vehicle through which a legitimate political alternative can be pursued. The danger is that using this historical narrative as a tool of political legitimation and mobilization reifies spheres of inclusivity and exclusivity, overlooks the complexity and diversity of the Kachin, and obfuscates the deeper issues peace processes and political dialogue need to address into a simplistic focus on federal power sharing.

EXPRESSION OF PROXIMAL CAUSE: INEQUALITY

The most common issue we heard from the Kachin we spoke with was a perception of having been systematically dismissed, suppressed, and sidelined. As Sadan (2013) notes, most Kachin feel they experience economic, social, and political discrimination, which they believe to be the result of deep-seated antagonism and hostility toward them by 'the Burman elite'. The government has never disputed that Kachin are citizens, but most — even the state officials and negotiators interviewed — agree that there has been institutionalized discrimination against all minorities, including the Kachin. This is corroborated by the 2015 Asian Barometer Survey results (see Welsh and Huang, this volume); also Welsh (2015) found fifty-nine per cent of those who identify as being from an 'ethnic minority' report discrimination, with much higher figures for respondents from non-Buddhist minorities. Even Kachin living in Yangon and urban centres expressed concern in our interviews that they are not treated as equal members of Myanmar society, and are discriminated against unless they hide their identity. Burman informants noted that even the country's ambassadors are all Burman, with none from ethnic minorities.

Numerous respondents expressed a fear that was encapsulated by a